

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 50 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Eight • Soft Skills

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Eight, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Eight covers fifty FIRSTS across six sections: Communication & Listening, Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness, Feedback & Conflict Resolution, Teamwork & Collaboration, Networking & Public Speaking, and Growth Mindset & Resilience. Note that the chapter numbers (L1-L50) do not run sequentially within each section — the manual's original numbering reflects a different internal order than the thematic grouping used here and throughout this stage's facilitator resources.

Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt. Suggested times are for framing and discussion only; independent worksheet time is scheduled separately in the companion Session Plan.

SESSION 1

Communication & Listening

Covers: L1, L4, L30, L36, L37, L39, L40, L49

FIRST L1

Active Listening Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice a real conversation where they listen to understand rather than to reply, and can identify the difference afterward.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people listen to reply, not to understand — this produces conversations that feel disjointed and erodes trust over time.
- Genuinely understanding someone first builds far stronger relationships than rushing to respond.
- This is the foundational skill for the whole section — everything else in Communication & Listening builds on it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Nodding along while mentally drafting your reply, which looks like listening but isn't.
 - Assuming you're already a good listener without ever genuinely testing it.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L4

Assertive Communication Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice stating a real need clearly, without either passive avoidance or aggressive overcorrection.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Passive communication leaves real needs unmet; aggressive communication damages relationships — assertiveness is the middle path that gets results without that cost.
- This is a practiced skill, not a personality trait some people simply have.
- Watch for over-apologizing, which quietly undercuts the assertiveness before the actual point lands.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-apologizing before stating the actual need, which undercuts the message.
 - Confusing assertiveness with aggression, and avoiding it entirely as a result.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L30

Communication Style Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify their own default communication style and check it against how others actually experience it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people have a default style they're only partially aware of, and it can land differently than intended.
- Self-perception and actual impact are genuinely different things — this exercise closes that gap.
- This connects directly to Assertive Communication (L4) — knowing your default style shapes what you need to practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming self-perception matches how others actually experience you, without ever checking.
- Treating communication style as fixed rather than something you can deliberately adjust.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L36

Listening Without Interrupting Challenge

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants go through one full real conversation without interrupting, even with good intentions.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Interrupting, even to “help” finish someone's thought, signals that your point matters more than fully hearing theirs.
- This subtly damages trust over time, even when it feels well-intentioned in the moment.
- This is genuinely harder than it sounds — most people interrupt far more than they realize.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Interrupting to “help” finish someone's thought, which often isn't actually welcome.
- Believing you rarely interrupt, without ever having tracked it honestly.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L37

Body Language Awareness Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one specific non-verbal habit of their own and observe how it lands in a real interaction.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Non-verbal cues often communicate more than words do.
- Being unaware of your own body language can undercut an otherwise strong verbal message.
- The goal is awareness, not constant self-monitoring — overcorrecting into hyper-awareness has its own cost.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Focusing so much on managing your own body language that you stop actually listening.
- Assuming body language is universal rather than genuinely context- and culture-dependent.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L39

Inclusive Communication Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice deliberately inviting a quieter group member into a real discussion.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Groups default to hearing from the most confident or vocal members, missing valuable quieter perspectives.
- Silence is often a need for explicit invitation, not agreement or lack of opinion.
- This is a concrete, practicable habit, not just a value to hold abstractly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming silence means agreement or genuine lack of opinion.
- Inviting quieter members so generically (“any thoughts, anyone?”) that it doesn't actually work.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L40

Empathetic Response Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice acknowledging someone's feelings before offering any advice or solution.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people's instinct when someone shares a problem is to immediately offer solutions.
- What's often actually needed first is to feel genuinely understood, not immediately fixed.
- This directly complements Active Listening (L1) with a specific response pattern.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Jumping straight to advice or comparison (“that happened to me too”) before acknowledging feelings.
- Assuming empathy and agreement are the same thing.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L49

Listening for Understanding Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice summarizing what someone said before responding, in a real conversation.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Summarizing forces genuine processing, rather than just hearing words while mentally drafting a response.
- This closes the section by turning L1's listening principle into a concrete, checkable habit.
- Under time pressure, summarizing can feel like it slows things down — it's worth it anyway.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming you understood correctly without actually checking, especially under time pressure.
- Summarizing mechanically without genuinely confirming accuracy with the other person.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 2

Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness

Covers: L2, L15, L16, L21, L29, L43, L45, L48

FIRST L2

Empathy Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reflect on a recent disagreement from the other person's genuine perspective, after the fact.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Empathy doesn't always come automatically in the moment, especially during disagreement.
- Deliberately reflecting afterward builds the habit of considering perspective proactively, in the moment, next time.
- This is the foundation for the entire Emotional Intelligence section.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only doing this reflection after conflict has already caused real damage.
 - Confusing empathy with agreement — you can understand a perspective without endorsing it.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L15

Emotional Awareness Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one recurring emotional reaction pattern and observe it with curiosity rather than judgment.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without conscious awareness of your own emotional patterns, you tend to react the same way repeatedly, even when it isn't serving you.
- The goal is neutral observation, not self-criticism — judgment tends to shut down honest reflection.
- This sets up Emotional Regulation (L43) later in the section, which requires this awareness first.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Judging yourself harshly for the reaction instead of simply observing the pattern with curiosity.
 - Assuming the pattern is fixed rather than something awareness can actually shift.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L16

Patience Challenge

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliberately practice patience in one small, real moment this week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Patience is a trainable skill, not just a fixed trait.
- Practicing in smaller moments genuinely builds capacity for bigger ones later.
- This is a real behavioral commitment, not just a reflection — push for a specific, concrete moment.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Suppressing frustration without actually processing it, which can build up rather than genuinely dissipate.
- Waiting for a big moment to practice patience instead of starting with something small.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L21

Perspective-Taking Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants genuinely articulate a real disagreement from more than one side, not just their own.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most disagreements look completely reasonable from both sides.
- Genuinely considering multiple viewpoints leads to better decisions and more empathetic responses.
- The real test is whether you can state the other side's view in a way they'd recognize as fair.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Doing the exercise while secretly still assuming your own view is the correct one.
- Articulating a weakened, strawman version of the other perspective rather than its genuine strongest form.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L29

Emotional Intelligence Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build genuinely specific emotional vocabulary rather than relying on vague, generic labels.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Emotional intelligence starts with accurate identification — you can't manage or respond well to an emotion you haven't correctly named.

- “Fine” or “stressed” are starting points, not endpoints — push for real specificity.
- This directly supports L15's pattern awareness with a richer, more precise vocabulary.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using only vague, generic emotional labels instead of building genuinely specific vocabulary.
- Assuming naming an emotion accurately is the same as having addressed it.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L43

Emotional Regulation Drill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify and practice one specific regulation technique before they genuinely need it under real pressure.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Emotional regulation improves with deliberate practice, not something you either have or don't.
- Specific techniques give you something concrete to reach for under real pressure, rather than improvising in the moment.
- Practice this now, at low stakes, not for the first time during an actual crisis.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Waiting until you're already overwhelmed to try a technique for the first time.
- Assuming one technique works universally without testing what genuinely helps you.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L45

Cultural Awareness Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reflect honestly on a real cross-cultural interaction and what they genuinely learned from it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Increasingly diverse environments require genuine cultural awareness, not just tolerance.
- Understanding real differences and similarities builds better working relationships.
- This is an ongoing, evolving practice, not a single completed checkbox.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating cultural awareness as a one-time checkbox rather than an ongoing practice.
- Overgeneralizing from a single interaction to an entire culture or group.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L48

Personal Values Statement Written

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a values statement grounded in how they've genuinely behaved, not just how they'd like to be seen.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A clear, written values statement helps guide decisions and behavior consistently, rather than reacting differently each time based on mood.
- This closes the section by turning emotional self-awareness into an explicit, actionable standard.
- The real test is whether it reflects genuine past behavior, not just aspirational language.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing a values statement that sounds impressive but doesn't actually reflect real behavior.
- Treating this as a one-time writing exercise rather than something to revisit and check against.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 3

Feedback & Conflict Resolution

Covers: L5, L6, L3, L23, L35, L31, L9, L33

FIRST L5

Feedback Given

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants give one real, specific piece of feedback to a peer this week, rather than avoiding it out of discomfort.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people avoid giving feedback out of discomfort, which deprives peers of genuinely useful input.
- Specificity matters far more than diplomacy — vague, softened feedback often isn't actually useful.
- This is the foundation for the whole section; everything else assumes a baseline willingness to give real feedback.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding giving feedback entirely out of discomfort.
 - Softening feedback so much it loses any genuine, actionable content.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L6

Feedback Received Gracefully

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice receiving real feedback without becoming defensive or immediately explaining their reasoning.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- How you respond to feedback in the moment shapes whether people feel comfortable giving you honest input in the future.
- Defensiveness, even subtle, discourages future honesty from the people around you.
- This directly pairs with L5 — a group that can both give and receive feedback well changes fastest.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Becoming defensive or immediately explaining your reasoning, which discourages future honesty.
 - Agreeing outwardly while privately dismissing the feedback entirely.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L3

Conflict Resolution Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants address one real, current disagreement directly rather than continuing to avoid it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Avoided conflict doesn't disappear — it tends to resurface worse later.
- Addressing disagreement directly and constructively is a distinct, learnable skill, not just a personality trait.
- This is genuinely uncomfortable for most people; normalize that discomfort rather than pretending it away.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding the conversation entirely, which tends to make the underlying issue worse over time.
- Confusing directness with harshness — constructive conflict resolution is neither passive nor aggressive.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L23

Team Conflict Debrief

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants debrief a real past team conflict, identifying what should genuinely change going forward.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without deliberate debriefing, teams tend to repeat the same conflict patterns rather than genuinely learning.
- The value is in specific, actionable takeaways, not just processing what happened emotionally.
- This extends L3's individual skill into a team-level practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping the debrief once immediate tension has passed, missing the chance to prevent recurrence.
- Focusing only on assigning blame rather than identifying a genuine, actionable change.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L35

Conflict Mediation Role Played

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice mediating a role-played conflict between two other people while staying genuinely neutral.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Mediation is a distinct skill from resolving your own conflicts.
- Staying genuinely neutral while helping two other people communicate is valuable for both team dynamics and future leadership.
- Even subtly taking a side undermines a mediator's credibility with both parties.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Unconsciously taking a side, even subtly, which undermines mediator credibility.
- Trying to solve the conflict yourself rather than facilitating the two parties toward their own resolution.

SUGGESTED TIME: *25 min (role-play format)*

FIRST L31

Team Feedback Session Facilitated

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants facilitate a structured feedback session for a real team, with explicit ground rules.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Team feedback sessions without structure often become either too vague to be useful or uncomfortably personal.
- Facilitation keeps them genuinely productive — explicit ground rules matter more than people expect.
- This is the most advanced FIRST in this section, combining L5, L6, and L35's skills into one facilitated practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting the session drift into vague positivity or uncomfortable personal criticism without structure.
- Facilitating passively rather than actively keeping the session on track.

SUGGESTED TIME: *25 min*

FIRST L9

Negotiation Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice a real, collaborative negotiation (resource, deadline, or task-related) rather than an adversarial one.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Negotiation is relevant far beyond salary discussions — everyday resource allocation, deadlines, and task division all count.
- Approaching it collaboratively rather than adversarially produces better outcomes for both sides.
- This connects to L4's Assertive Communication from Section 1 — negotiation is assertiveness applied to a specific, structured context.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating negotiation as purely adversarial, missing solutions that could genuinely serve both sides.
 - Conceding too quickly to avoid discomfort, rather than genuinely exploring mutual options.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST L33

Boundary Setting Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants state one real professional boundary clearly and hold it, without over-apologizing.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without practiced boundaries, it's easy to become overcommitted or resentful, which damages relationships more than a respectfully stated limit would.
- Over-apologizing or over-explaining a boundary can invite pushback on something you actually need to hold firm.
- This closes the section by turning feedback and conflict skills toward protecting your own genuine capacity.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-apologizing or over-explaining the boundary, which can invite pushback.
 - Setting a boundary so rigidly it reads as inflexible rather than reasonable.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 4

Teamwork & Collaboration

Covers: L7, L8, L32, L18, L42, L44, L34, L47, L19

FIRST L7

Collaboration Challenge Completed

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants push through one genuinely challenging collaboration rather than retreating to solo work at the first sign of friction.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Easy collaborations don't build much skill; genuinely challenging ones, with real friction, are where collaborative skill actually develops.
- The instinct to retreat into solo work under friction is common and worth naming explicitly.
- This is the foundation for the whole section — real teamwork skill only develops under genuine difficulty.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Giving up on genuine collaboration at the first sign of friction, retreating into solo work.
 - Avoiding genuinely challenging collaborations in favor of easy, low-friction ones.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L8

Team Role Assumed

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliberately choose and commit to a specific team role rather than defaulting to whatever feels comfortable.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Deliberately choosing and committing to a role helps a team function more effectively than everyone defaulting to comfort.
- This is a conscious choice, not just falling into whatever role happens to be left.
- Sets up L44 (Team Role Rotation) later in this section, which pushes this further into unfamiliar roles.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Always taking the same comfortable role by default, missing growth from trying something different.
 - Choosing a role passively rather than deliberately committing to it.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L32

Collaborative Brainstorm

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants run a structured brainstorm with an explicit judgment-free generation phase before any evaluation.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unstructured group brainstorming often produces fewer and lower-quality ideas than a deliberately structured session.
- Judgment and social dynamics suppress genuine idea generation if evaluation happens too early.
- Separate generation from evaluation explicitly, as two distinct phases.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Judging or discussing ideas during the generation phase, which suppresses the range of ideas produced.
- Letting the most vocal person's early idea anchor the whole session.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L18

Problem-Solving Discussion

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants run a structured discussion that genuinely draws out multiple perspectives before converging on a solution.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Group problem-solving often surfaces solutions no individual would have reached alone — but only with genuine structure.
- Converging on the first idea offered, usually from the most vocal person, wastes this potential.
- This directly extends L32's brainstorming structure into applied problem-solving.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Converging on the first idea offered without genuinely exploring other perspectives first.
- Mistaking a quick consensus for a genuinely good solution.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L42

Group Decision Facilitated

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants facilitate a group decision, explicitly checking for unaddressed concerns before finalizing it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Decisions reached without genuine buy-in often unravel later.
- Facilitating toward real consensus, not just a majority vote, produces more durable, committed outcomes.
- Explicitly checking for quiet dissent is the specific skill this FIRST is building.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Rushing to a vote or the loudest opinion without checking for unaddressed concerns.
- Mistaking silence for agreement rather than genuinely confirming it.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L44

Team Role Rotation Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliberately take on an unfamiliar team role and stay committed to it, even under pressure.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Sticking to the same comfortable role limits growth; deliberately rotating into unfamiliar ones builds flexibility.
- This often reveals strengths a person might not have discovered otherwise.
- Watch for reverting to the comfortable default role specifically when pressure increases.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reverting to your comfortable default role under pressure instead of committing to the new one.
- Choosing a “new” role that's actually adjacent to your comfortable one rather than genuinely different.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L34

Adaptation to Remote/Virtual Work

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one specific habit adjustment needed for effective remote or virtual collaboration.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Remote and virtual teamwork requires different habits than in-person collaboration, since informal cues are lost.
- Text communication often reads more harshly or ambiguously than intended — this is a common, avoidable friction point.
- More deliberate, explicit communication compensates for what's lost in a remote setting.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming text communication carries the same tone and context as in-person conversation.

- Under-communicating remotely, assuming things are understood without explicit confirmation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L47

Peer Recognition Shared

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants give one specific, genuine piece of public recognition to a peer's real contribution.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine contributions often go unnoticed without deliberate acknowledgment.
- Public recognition builds team morale and reinforces the behaviors worth repeating.
- Specificity is what separates genuine recognition from empty praise.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Giving vague, generic praise ("great job everyone") instead of specific, genuine recognition.
- Reserving recognition only for the most visible contributions, missing quieter but genuine ones.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L19

Decision-Making Log

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants log a real decision's rationale at the time it's made, not retroactively once the outcome is known.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a documented rationale, it's hard to learn from past decisions, since honest memory of the reasoning fades quickly.
- Logging after the outcome is known distorts the honest record — timing matters here.
- This closes the section, turning the team decision-making practiced throughout into a genuine learning record.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only logging decisions after the fact, once the outcome is already known.
- Logging outcomes rather than the actual reasoning behind the decision.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

SESSION 5

Networking & Public Speaking

Covers: L10, L11, L12, L13, L14, L22, L38, L41, L46

FIRST L10

Public Speaking Confidence Drill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice speaking in front of real people, not just alone, to build audience-specific comfort.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Content mastery and audience comfort are distinct challenges — knowing your material doesn't guarantee comfort delivering it.
- Practicing specifically in front of real people builds comfort that solo rehearsal alone doesn't provide.
- This is the foundation for the whole section; everything else builds on genuine, practiced comfort.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only ever practicing alone, which doesn't build the specific comfort needed for a real audience.
 - Assuming confidence must exist before practicing, rather than building through practice itself.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L11

Presentation to Mixed Audience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants adapt tone and language within a single presentation for genuinely different audience segments.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A single presentation style rarely lands equally well with a truly mixed audience.
- Adapting tone and language for different segments within the same room is a distinct, valuable skill.
- Push participants to identify the actual segments in their real or likely audience, not treat it as uniform.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming a uniform audience and pitching entirely to one segment, losing the rest of the room.
 - Over-adapting to the point of losing a coherent core message.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L12

Networking Conversation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants have one real networking conversation approached with genuine curiosity, not a transactional agenda.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Networking that feels transactional rarely produces genuine relationships.
- Approaching it with real curiosity about the other person produces more durable, valuable connections.
- This reframes networking away from “what can I get” toward genuine mutual interest.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating the conversation as transactional, focused on what you can get from it.
- Over-preparing a pitch about yourself instead of genuinely asking about the other person.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L13

Peer Mentoring Session

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants mentor a peer through guiding questions rather than simply doing the task for them.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Peer mentoring is a distinct skill from being mentored — teaching a peer deepens your own understanding too.
- Doing the task for someone instead of guiding them undercuts the actual value of mentoring.
- This builds genuine leadership capability, not just helpfulness.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Just doing the task for the person instead of guiding them toward their own understanding.
- Giving answers immediately rather than asking questions that help them find their own.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L14

Mentor Interaction

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare specific, genuine questions before a real mentor conversation, rather than showing up passively.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A mentoring relationship's value depends heavily on how well you engage with it.

- Thoughtful questions and genuine application make the relationship far more valuable than passive listening.
- This is the flip side of L13 — being a genuinely engaged mentee, not just a genuinely engaged mentor.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Showing up to mentor conversations without any specific questions prepared.
- Treating mentor advice as instructions to follow exactly, rather than input to genuinely consider.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L22

Networking Follow-Up Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants send one genuine, non-transactional follow-up message to a real networking contact.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most networking value is lost not at the initial meeting but in the failure to follow up consistently afterward.
- Proactive follow-up is what actually sustains a relationship over time.
- Only reaching out when you need something reads as transactional — flag this explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only reaching out when you need something, which reads as transactional.
- Letting too much time pass before following up, losing the natural connection from the original conversation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L38

Networking Event Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reflect honestly on a real networking event and identify one specific thing to genuinely improve next time.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without deliberate reflection, networking approach tends to stay static rather than genuinely improving.
- Skipping reflection because the event is over is an easy, common trap — name it directly.
- This closes the loop on L12 and L22, turning individual practice into an improving pattern over time.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping reflection because the event is over and moving on feels easier.

- Reflecting only on how you felt rather than what specifically you'd do differently.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L41

Presentation Handling Q&A

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice pausing briefly before answering an unscripted question, rather than rushing immediately.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unscripted Q&A often reveals more about genuine understanding and composure than the prepared portion of a presentation ever does.
- Rushing to answer immediately out of nervousness often produces a less clear, more rambling response than a brief pause would allow.
- This is a distinct skill from prepared delivery, worth practicing separately.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Rushing to answer immediately out of nervousness, producing a less clear response.
- Treating every question as one you must have a perfect answer to on the spot.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L46

Motivational Speech Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver a short motivational speech grounded in a genuine, specific personal story rather than generic inspiration.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Motivational speaking is a distinct skill from informational presenting, requiring genuine energy and emotional connection.
- Generic inspirational language falls flat; specific personal conviction or story genuinely lands.
- This closes the section by combining confidence, audience awareness, and genuine authenticity.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying on generic inspirational language instead of a genuine, specific personal conviction or story.
- Prioritizing polish over authenticity, which often reads as less genuinely motivating.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 6

Growth Mindset & Resilience

Covers: L17, L20, L24, L25, L26, L27, L28, L50

FIRST L17

Adaptability Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify a real, recent unexpected change and practice responding constructively rather than with immediate frustration.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unexpected change is inevitable in any real project or career.
- The ability to adapt quickly and constructively is a distinct, trainable skill, not just a fixed personality trait.
- This is the foundation for the whole section — growth mindset starts with how you respond to the unplanned.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reacting to unexpected change with immediate frustration or rigidity.
 - Assuming adaptability is innate rather than something built through deliberate practice.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L20

Critical Thinking Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants examine a real first impression of someone or something as a hypothesis to test, not settled fact.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Snap judgments about people or social situations are often wrong.
- Deliberately analyzing before concluding produces more accurate, fair assessments.
- Treat first impressions explicitly as hypotheses worth examining, not conclusions.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating a first impression as settled fact rather than a hypothesis worth examining.
 - Confusing confidence in a judgment with its actual accuracy.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST L24

Leadership Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reflect honestly on a real leadership moment, including one that didn't go especially well.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Leadership style often develops unconsciously through habit.
- Deliberate reflection surfaces both genuine strengths and blind spots you might not otherwise notice.
- The more valuable lessons are often found in moments that didn't go well, not just successes.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reflecting only on successes, missing the more valuable lessons in moments that didn't go well.
- Reflecting on leadership in the abstract rather than one genuine, specific moment.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST L25

Stress Management Technique Practiced

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants try one specific stress management technique and honestly assess whether it genuinely works for them.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Consistent stress management prevents burnout and supports better decision-making under pressure.
- Different techniques work better for different people and situations — there's no universal answer.
- This connects directly to L43 (Emotional Regulation Drill) from Section 2, applied specifically to stress.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming one popular technique (like meditation) will work for everyone, without experimenting.
- Trying a technique once and abandoning it rather than giving it a genuine trial period.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST L26

Gratitude Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write genuine, specific gratitude entries, not generic or repetitive ones.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Consistent gratitude practice measurably improves mood and outlook, particularly during stressful periods.
- Specificity is what makes this genuinely effective rather than just an empty ritual.
- Particularly useful to introduce during a stressful stretch, like a job search or heavy workload.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing generic, repetitive entries that feel more like an obligation than a genuine practice.
- Treating gratitude practice as a one-time exercise rather than something sustained.

SUGGESTED TIME: *10 min*

FIRST L27

Resilience Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants work deliberately through a real, genuine setback toward one concrete next step.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Resilience is a trainable skill, not just a fixed trait.
- Deliberately and intentionally working through a setback builds the capacity to recover faster from future ones.
- The two failure modes are suppressing disappointment entirely or dwelling on it indefinitely — neither builds genuine resilience.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Either suppressing the disappointment entirely or dwelling on it indefinitely.
- Skipping to “moving on” without genuinely processing what happened first.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST L28

Time Management Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants examine their own real time-use patterns rather than adopting a generic productivity system untested.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Generic productivity advice doesn't account for individual variation.
- Genuine self-reflection reveals your own specific patterns, which produces more effective personal systems.
- This closes the loop with earlier stages' productivity work, applied through a soft-skills, self-awareness lens.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Adopting a generic productivity system without checking whether it actually fits your own real patterns.
- Assuming a system that worked for someone else will automatically work for you.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST L50

Reflection on Soft Skill Growth

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants honestly review their practice across the entire stage and name a genuine strength and a genuine remaining gap.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Looking across the whole stage's worth of practice reveals genuine growth patterns that no single FIRST alone would show.
- This closes out Stage Eight entirely — give it real room rather than rushing it.
- Honesty about genuinely difficult areas matters more here than in any single earlier reflection.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reviewing only the skills that feel comfortable to reflect on, avoiding honest assessment of difficult areas.
- Treating this as a formality rather than a genuine, comprehensive self-assessment.

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min